

Draw on Mind Maps

Mind maps are used for two things—memory and creativity. Though managers and students make the most out of it, mind maps can be useful to anyone. Here are some areas where you can put these to use.

Self-analysis: Use it to analyse your needs and future goals. Long-term decisions such as career switches are taken effectively using this tool. Look at the direction the thoughts in your map take you, and you have a decision at hand!

Diary: Unlike a conventional planner, a mind map diary can be used for time management—write little notes pertaining to the time at which you need things done. It can also be used

to record events in a memorable and interesting manner—map your holiday trips, for example, and attach your anecdotes to the ‘places’ where they occurred.

Group study: It has been found that, together with group study, the Mind Map Organic Study Technique (MMOST) increases the pace, understanding, effectiveness and efficiency of learning. Visit <http://www.mindmapping.co.uk/studying.htm> and <http://www.happychild.org.uk/acc/tpr/features/0109mmmap.htm> for more information on MMOST.

Creative Writing: Arrange and rearrange your thoughts before you begin to write using this tool. Students will find this technique very useful to write essays,

just as this writer did for this story.

Exam preparations: Make notes while studying, so that you can review them later. You can also map your answers to cover all points.

Teaching: Plan lessons, presentations, projects and examinations.

Speeches or lectures: Mind maps can also be used to structure your thoughts before you give a speech.

Meetings: Ideas generated by meetings and brainstorming can be very well arranged in a mind map. You can collect ideas and arrange them into logical groups, for an easy analysis.

Business: Structure a complete company with this tool. It is also a very powerful marketing and planning tool.

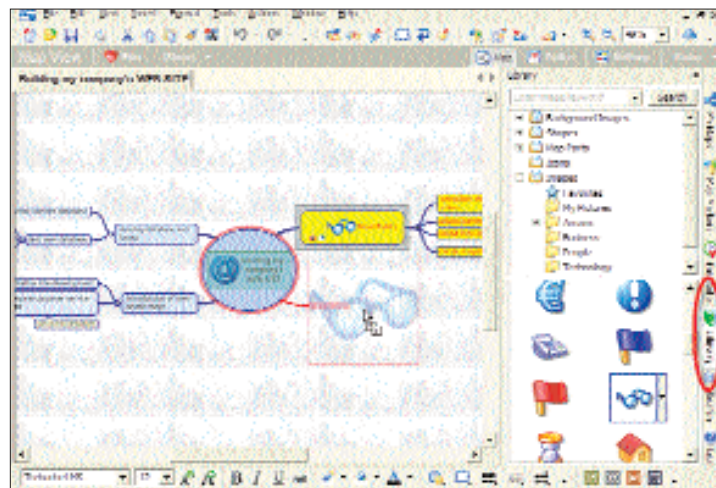
a callout and a callout a topic. Moving the focus between the components of a map is also very easy. Use [Tab] to jump to the next topic in the clockwise direction, and [Shift] + [Tab] to move counter-clockwise. You can also use the arrow keys to move in the respective direction. You can even move the entire map. Click on the background, hold the left mouse button till the pointer changes to a hand, and then drag.

To reorganise the map, click the topic you want to move, and drag it to the new location. A visual clue shows you the position where this topic will be placed. If you press and hold [Ctrl] while dragging and dropping, a copy of that topic is created and placed at the new location. Delete a topic with all its sub-topics, by selecting it and pressing [Del]. If you wish to do away with just the topic, press [Ctrl] + [Del] instead.

Formatting your mind map

Make your maps visually distinct to enhance their appeal. Use the inbuilt styles, or create and use your own style.

Go to **Format > Style > Assign from Template Organizer...**, choose a style and click OK. Individually formatted elements won't be touched. Format them using the Formatting toolbar



Insert images using the Library task pane to create visually appealing maps

at the bottom of MindManager. Change fonts, colours, add shapes, boundaries and lines. Use the Library tab to insert an image that links to a topic, or just floats freely.

Fine-tuning maps

To make your maps easy to comprehend—which is their intent—keep topics as short as possible. Use notes to attach additional information to a topic. Notes come in useful when exporting maps to Web pages or a Microsoft Word document. Select the topic and press [Ctrl] + [T], or go to **Insert > Notes**. This opens the Topic Notes window for you to type your notes, which can contain formatted text, links and images. Topics with notes attached, display an icon next to them in the map view. Move your mouse over this icon to read the note.

Another useful component is Task Information, which helps to schedule, pri-



Sites to Visit

Here is a list of software that you can use to create mind maps:

Windows software

MindGenius Business (<http://www.mindgenius.com/website/home.aspx>): Plan those business moves as you move up the ladder. Different versions of this software let you chart your education, and even daily chores.

Visual Mind 5.01 (<http://www.visual-mind.com/vv2.htm?335351>): This software closely competes with MindManager in terms of simplicity.

PDA Software

MindManager 2002 Mobile Edition ([http://www.mindjet.com/us/products/comcompare.php](http://www.mindjet.com/us/products/compare.php)):

Here's a PDA version of the software:

Idea Pad for Palm (<http://www.palmgear.com/index.cfm?fuseaction=software.show-software&prodid=53084>): Use it to create a work pattern in the Palm of your hand!

Free Software

FreeMind (<http://freemind.sourceforge.net/>) Prioritise your goals and draw up an action plan with FreeMind, written in Java.